

KELSEY PUKELIS

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EDUCATION

Harvard University, Cambridge, MA 2025

Ph.D. in Public Policy (Economics Track)

Fields: Public Economics, Labor Economics

Research Interests: Social Safety Net Policy, U.S. Nutrition Assistance Policy

M.A. in Public Policy

Northwestern University, Evanston, IL 2017

B.A. in Economics, Mathematics, Mathematical Methods in the Social Sciences (triple major)

Interdisciplinary Honors in Economics & Mathematical Methods in the Social Sciences

Cum Laude; Phi Beta Kappa

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

California Department of Social Services, Sacramento, CA

Research, Automation, and Data Division

Principal Researcher (Research Data Specialist III)

Jan 2026 – Present

Research Data Specialist I

Jun 2025 – Jan 2026

Harvard Kennedy School of Government, Cambridge, MA

May 2025 – Present

Research Fellow (unpaid)

Taubman Center for State & Local Government

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Harvard Kennedy School of Government, Cambridge, MA

Poverty & Public Policy (Master of Public Policy)

Spring 2025

Guest Co-Lecturer with Professor Mark Shepard (2 sessions)

Quantitative Analysis & Empirical Methods II (Master of Public Policy)

Spring 2023

Teaching Fellow for Professors Michela Carlana, Benjamin Schneer & Teddy Svoronos

Resources, Incentives, & Choices II: Analysis of Public Policy (Master of Public Policy)

Spring 2022

Teaching Fellow for Professor Mark Shepard

University of Virginia, Charlottesville, VA

Advanced Topics in Impact Evaluation (Master of Public Policy)

Fall 2018

Teaching Assistant for Professor Sally Hudson

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Microsoft Research New England, Cambridge, MA

Summer 2020

Research Intern with Eleanor Dillon

University of Virginia, Charlottesville, VA

2017 – 2019

Frank Batten School of Leadership & Public Policy

Research Specialist Intermediate to Jennifer Doleac, Sally Hudson, and Adam Leive

FELLOWSHIPS & AWARDS

James M. and Cathleen D. Stone Scholar in Inequality, Harvard University	2021 – 2025
National Science Foundation Graduate Research Fellowship	2021 – 2024
Harvard Graduate Prize Fellowship	2019 – 2021

RESEARCH GRANTS

Institute for Quantitative Social Science Graduate Student Research Grant, Harvard University	2024
Malcolm Wiener Center for Social Policy Qualitative Research Grant, Harvard University	2024
Stone Research Grant, James M. and Cathleen D. Stone Program in Wealth Distribution, Inequality & Social Policy, Harvard University	2023
Division of Social Sciences Fund, Harvard University	2022
Mind Brain Behavior Graduate Student Award, Harvard University	2021
Harvard Center for American Political Studies Graduate Seed Grant	2021

PUBLICATION

“Employed in a SNAP? The Impact of Work Requirements on Program Participation and Labor Supply” (with Colin Gray, Adam Leive, Elena Prager, and Mary Zaki)
American Economic Journal: Economic Policy, 2023, 15(1): 306-341.

Work requirements are common in US safety net programs. Evidence remains limited, however, on the extent to which work requirements increase economic self-sufficiency or screen out vulnerable individuals. Using linked administrative data on food stamps (SNAP) and earnings with a regression discontinuity design, we find robust evidence that work requirements increase program exits by 23 percentage points (64 percent) among incumbent participants. Overall program participation among adults who are subject to work requirements is reduced by 53 percent. Homeless adults are disproportionately screened out. We find no effects on employment and suggestive evidence of increased earnings in some specifications.

WORKING PAPERS

“SNAP Policies and Enrollment following the COVID-19 Pandemic”

Following the COVID-19 pandemic, the national budget of the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP) doubled, its caseload increased by 10 percent, and its application denial rate increased by nearly 50 percent. This paper investigates the factors behind these persistent enrollment changes, including economic conditions and policy changes. I compile a new dataset on state policy waivers during the COVID-19 public health emergency, including unprecedented flexibilities in enrollment procedures and increases in benefit amounts, and I use state-level policy variation to understand the effects of each policy on SNAP caseloads. I find that emergency supplemental benefits and recertification waivers drove enrollment increases. I estimate an elasticity of SNAP enrollment with respect to benefit size of 0.09-0.18. Descriptive evidence suggests that application denial rates increased both because recertification waivers cut off the typical flow of approved applications from otherwise churning cases and because relatively higher income households were more likely to apply. These results suggest that government policies can be more influential than economic conditions in determining transfer program caseload patterns.

“Stigma and Social Safety Net Program Participation” (with Michael Holcomb)

Negative social judgements or “stigma” about the receipt of government benefits may discourage participation and impose costs on those already receiving benefits. But who experiences stigma, how it affects participant decisions, and whether it can be reduced remain unclear. In this paper, we use a nationally representative survey experiment to measure levels of stigma across social groups and test whether interventions intended to alleviate stigma may affect participation in the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program (SNAP), the U.S.’ largest, means-tested food assistance program. We find that our interventions have polarizing effects: they increase stigma among Republicans and current SNAP participants and decrease stigma among Democrats and non-participants. One intervention that dismantles a common zero-sum concern (that receiving benefits would prevent others from receiving them) increases take-up among eligible non-participants, as measured by completing an online eligibility screener. However, all our interventions decrease support for SNAP spending among Republican respondents. Our findings indicate the importance of both social norms and political orientation for influencing participation in government transfer programs in this context.

“From Storefronts to Screens: The Impacts of Online Grocery Shopping on Public Food Assistance Users”

Many anti-poverty programs are in-kind, and adoption of new technology can alleviate the challenges associated with redeeming benefits. This project investigates how the availability of online grocery purchasing in public food assistance programs—including SNAP—affects food access, benefit spending patterns, and program participation. Authorization to accept Electronic Benefit Transfer (EBT) payments online was disproportionately adopted by large food retailers in urban areas. Exploiting the staggered roll-out of online purchasing authorization across retailers, I estimate that online exposure led to a \$16 increase in monthly online EBT spending per household. Households substitute away from in-store spending at large food retailers. Following a large drop in SNAP benefits, participants decrease online grocery spending more than dollar-for-dollar, suggesting that EBT consumers are willing to pay for convenience under higher incomes. Finally, online grocery purchasing availability increases local SNAP participation by 4 percent, primarily by increasing retention of existing participants. These results suggest that policies which reduce benefit redemption frictions can improve the effectiveness of in-kind benefit programs.

POLICY WRITING

Public comments on Proposed Rules to the U.S. Department of Agriculture, Food and Nutrition Service

- “Establishing the Summer Electronic Benefit Transfer Program & Rural Non-Congregate Option in the Summer Meal Programs” (FNS-2023-0029). Submitted on [Regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov), Aug. 27, 2024.
- “Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program: Program Purpose and Work Requirement Provisions of the Fiscal Responsibility Act of 2023” (FNS-2023-0058). Submitted on [Regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov), Jun. 14, 2024.
- “Special Supplemental Nutrition Program for Women, Infants, and Children: Online Ordering and Transactions and Food Delivery Revisions to Meet the Needs of a Modern, Data-Driven Program” (FNS-2022-0015-0001). Submitted on [Regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov), May 26, 2023.

“SNAP work requirements don’t actually get more people working — but they do drastically limit the availability of food aid.” *The Conversation*, April 2023.

CONFERENCE & SEMINAR PRESENTATIONS

“From Storefronts to Screens: The Impacts of Online Grocery Shopping on Public Food Assistance Users”		
AEA ASSA (American Economic Association)		Jan 2026
VEPPS (Virtual Economics of Poverty & Public Policy Seminar)		Dec 2025
APPAM (Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management)		Nov 2025
WEAI (Western Economic Association International)	(virtual)	Jun 2025
AAEA (Agriculture & Applied Economics Association)		Jul 2023
“Stigma and Safety Net Program Participation”		
ASHEcon (American Society of Health Economists)		Jun 2025
“SNAP Policies and Enrollment following the COVID-19 Pandemic”		
VEPPS (Virtual Economics of Poverty & Public Policy Seminar)	(short presentation)	Nov 2024
APPAM (Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management)		Nov 2024
SEA (Southern Economic Association)		Nov 2024
WEAI (Western Economic Association International)		Jul 2022

ACADEMIC SERVICE

Referee,	<i>Agriculture & Applied Economics Association Annual Meeting (2x)</i>	
	<i>Health Affairs Scholar</i>	
	<i>Journal of Policy Analysis and Management (2x)</i>	
	<i>Quarterly Journal of Economics (3x)</i>	
	<i>Review of Economics and Statistics</i>	
Reviewer,	<i>Oxford Bibliographies</i>	
Student-Faculty Engagement Co-Chair,	Harvard Kennedy PhD Student Association	2022 – 2023
Social Committee Co-Chair,	Harvard Kennedy PhD Student Association	2021 – 2022
Student Organizer,	Harvard Econometrics Reading Group	2020

MENTORING

Invited Panel Speaker,	Northwestern University’s Womxn in Economics Student Group	Fall 2023
Mentor,	Harvard Undergraduates for Inclusion in Economics	2022
Mentor,	MIT / Harvard Economics Application Assistance and Mentoring Program	2021 – 2022
Peer Mentor,	Harvard Public Policy PhD Program	2020 – 2022
Classroom & Language Consultant,	University of Virginia	2018 – 2019

AFFILIATIONS

Social Economics Lab, Harvard University, Affiliate
Institute for Quantitative Social Science, Harvard University, Affiliate
Mosaic Economic Project, Progressive Policy Institute, Alumna
American Economic Association Mentoring Program, Mentee
Agricultural & Applied Economics Association, Member

SKILLS

Computer	Proficient in Stata, R, SQL, L ^A T _E X, Git/GitHub, Microsoft Office Experience with Qualtrics, Python, Snowflake, HTML, BASH, ArcGIS, Matlab
Language	English (native), Spanish (fluent), Mandarin Chinese (basic)

REFERENCES

Joaquín Carbonell
California Department of Social Services
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Konrad Franco
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Marcella Alsan
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Jeffrey Liebman
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